



Anxiety in Tech

Dennie Declercq // 2022 // JavaZone Oslo

Intro

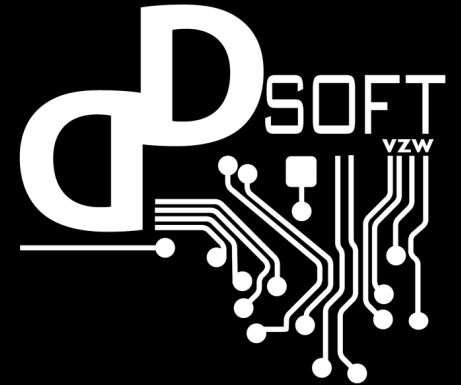
Content

- Intro
- Introduction to Anxiety
- Anxiety in Tech Tasks
- Anxiety in Tech Roles
- Indirect Anxiety in Tech
- How to cope anxiety
- Outro



Who am I?

- Dennie Declercq
- President & IT-coach DDSoft
- Microsoft MVP
- @DennieDeclercq
- **Mr. DreamingIsBelieving**

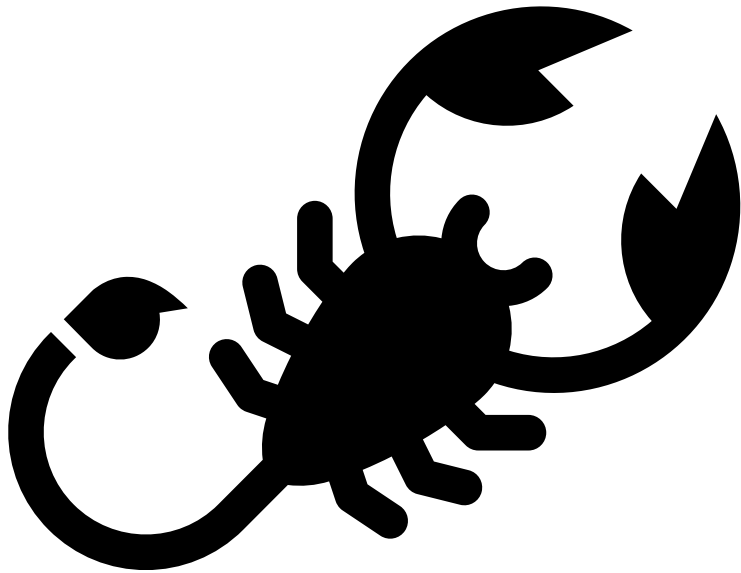


Travel lover
People lover
Modern Eastern Spirituality

How my history impacts my anxiety today

- As child I was bullied a lot.
- Big traumatic experience when I was 13yo (Child Psychiatry).
- The teachers didn't believe my programmers knowledge & abilities.
- My parents are not in tech.
- Recognition, Acceptance, Permission, Allowance always fighting points.





Introduction to Anxiety

Positive (High)	Joy		Amazement	
Negative (Low)	Anxiety	Rage	Grief	Aversion

What is Anxiety

- Prime Emotion
- Ancient Surviving **instinct** in danger
- Negative (Low Energy)

Types of Anxiety



Separation anxiety



Fear of rejection



Fear of failure

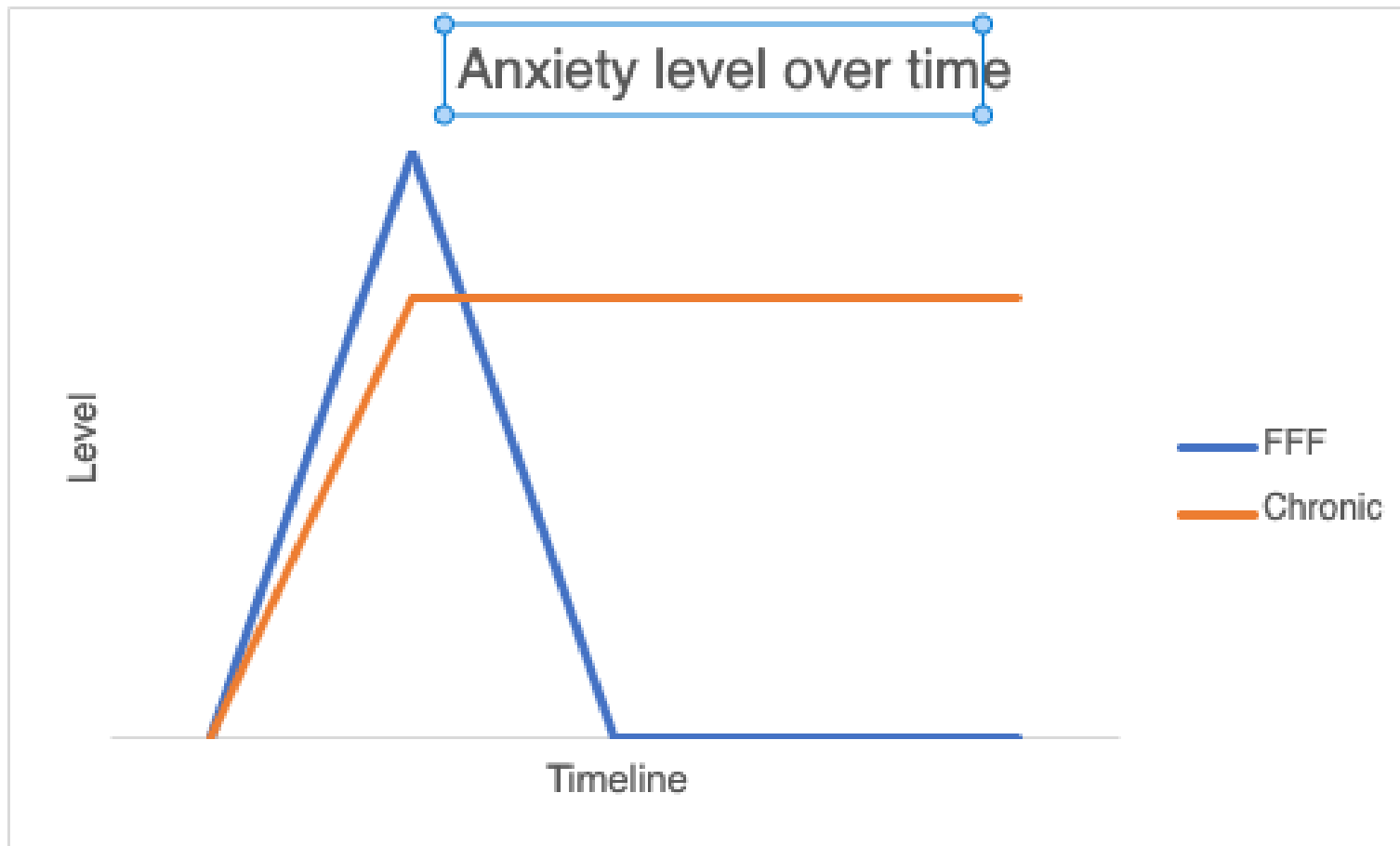


Fear of accusation



Fear of dying

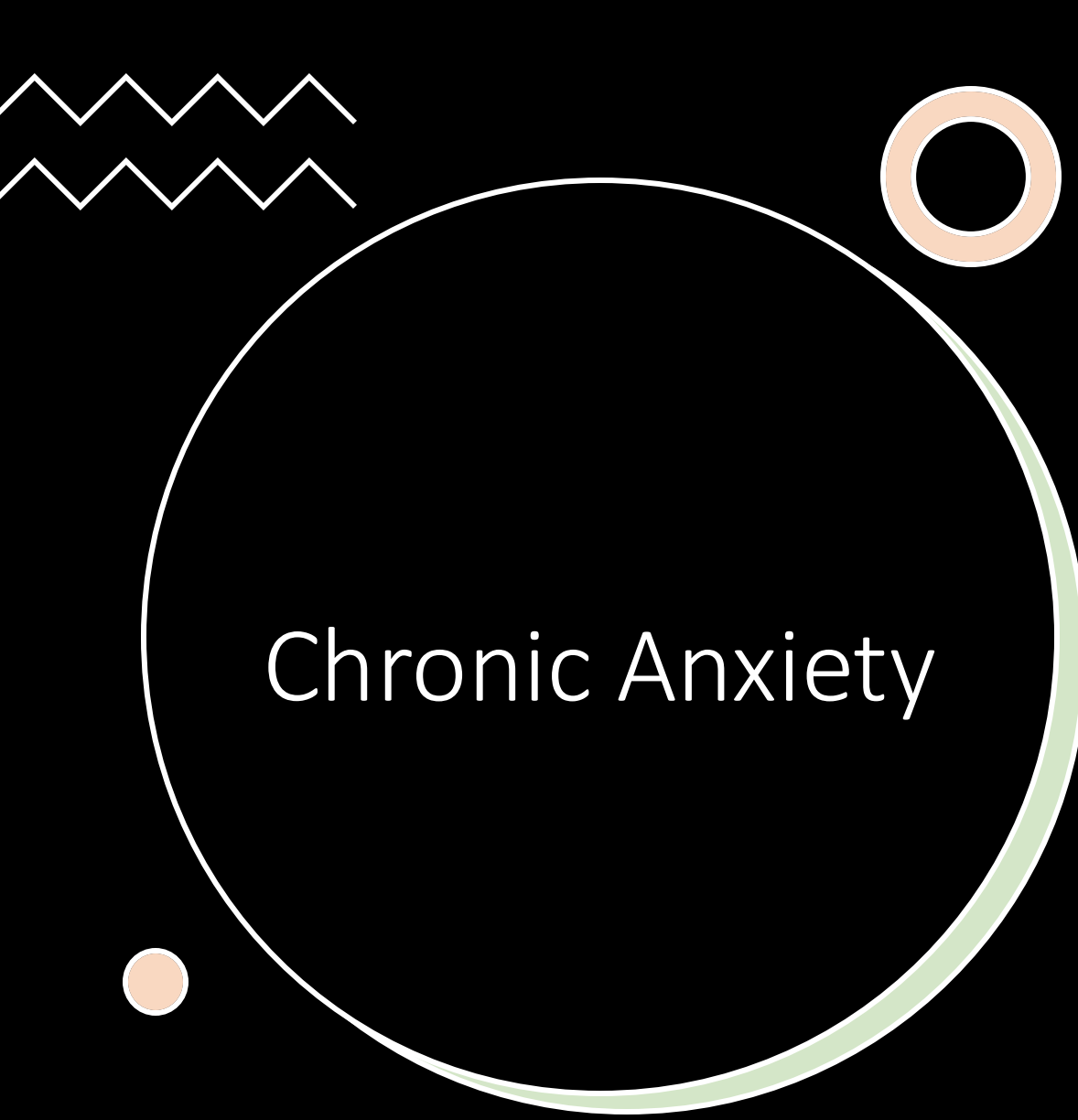
Duration of Anxiety





Fight, Flight, Freeze

- Basic instinct (Ancient animals)
- Real Fears
 - Car Crash
 - System Failure
 - Risk of bad choice
 - Risk of disastrous consequences
 - Unexpected bad customer call
- Panic



Chronic Anxiety

Long term

Long periods
of discomfort

Bad sleep/
Insomnia

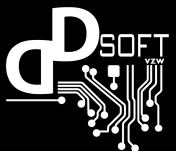
Mulling/
fretting

Hyper alert

Physical
tension

Your Mental Back-pack

- Direct impact on:
 - Feelings
 - Thoughts
 - Experiences
 - Circumstances happening right now
 - Brain wires
 - Physical body structure/ Muscles



Good vs Bad Anxiety

Good

- Can save you!
- Is short!

Bad

- All the rest

Anxiety in Tech Tasks

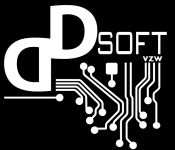


It works, Keep it (the legacy way)!

- It works, it's not perfect
- A rebuild can trigger new problems
- Low self-esteem causes anxiety
- What if a customer need it when it's broken?
- What if I can't fix it?

Bad Git Branches

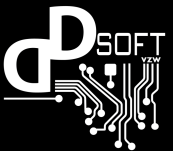
- A lack of Git usage is a major trigger
- Good Git knowledge definitely helps
- A solid branching strategy provide enough backups
- A roll-back strategy leads to safety



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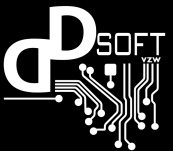
Unclear Package documentation

- Let's talk Maven, Gradle, NuGet, NPM
- What about package minor updates?
- What about package major updates?
- Are breaking changes announced?
- When is a version deprecated?
- Major changes & learning a complete new package is hell.



Unannounced breaking changes

- Breaking changes are not only in packages!
- Software (IDE's, Editors).
- Languages (Java, C, C#) versions.
- Frameworks (Angular, React, Node, .NET).



Announced
breaking
changes but
deadlines &
workload issues

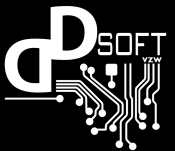
If a announced breaking change
with:

- Short due date
- A lot of work to do

In combination with:

- A lot of customer work
- Small team

Then, it can trigger loads of
Anxiety!



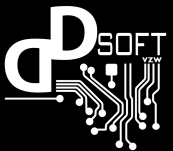
Alfa, Beta, Prod

You are using a Beta version from a 3rd party for your production...?

- You know you shouldn't.
- At first you saw only benefits.

And now your own production is broken?

- Are you scared for guilt feeling?
- How do you communicate with your customers?
- And/ or 3rd Party?

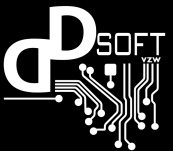


Left
behind if
too slow
to pivot

- You missed too much iterations of software (or a package) you are using:
 - Oh my God!
 - You procrastinated!
 - And you have only a very short time to fix...

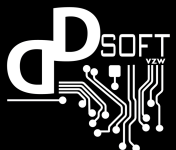
Cloud Architecture

- Your cloud Application works. It works, but it's too slow.
- You have paid customers/ users. Some complain. Some are OK (price).
- And there's a new Cloud Architecture that will solve your needs!
- Are you?
 - Scared to move and left the old project behind?
 - Brave enough to build it in a short timespan? Is it possible?
 - Do you mail your customers for an announced service stop (During Holidays)?
 - Just keep working the legacy way? With its trade-offs?



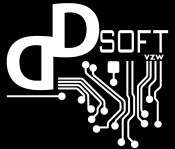
Security and Blaming

- Does security feels like safety? Of like danger?
- Is making your apps/systems secure stressfull?
- Will you get blamed even for good intent?
- Is good intent enough?
- Of do you put your dream project in a wintersleep?
 - Just for your security/ safety?





Anxiety in Tech Roles



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The downside of Work Hard/ Play Hard

- In a career, if you want to have succes:
 - You need to work hard;
 - Then, play hard!
- Success is a choice;
 - So, being unsuccessful too.
- My friends here in the room: Be honest?
 - Is this how we want to live?
 - Is this the legacy that we really want to leave?
 - Is this allways and for everyone possilbe? Really?



There's no Single Point of Contact



- For your customers you need:
 - 3rd Party hosting;
 - Personal contact is difficult, they are hard to reach.
- But your customers don't understand:
 - What 's your part;
 - What's the 3rd Party's part?
- How do you cope this?
- Are you frustrated?
- Are you anxious to loose your customer/money?



Part 1: Customers





Expectations

- Customer needs feature;
 - Customer 'need' it urgent;
 - You know you don't have capacity;
 - Are you promising for over-delivery?
 - Will you be anxious if you fail?
 - Is failure an option?
- Or are you saying: "It isn't possible"?
 - Is customer King?
 - Can a King do everything?
 - Will the customer leave? Anxious?

Borders & Limits

- Are you available allways?
- Day and night?
 - Or classic working hours?
- How can they contact you?
 - Work e-mail address?
 - Personal e-mail address?
 - LinkedIn DM?
 - Facebook Messenger DM?
 - WhatsApp?
- Can you communicate your limits and borders?

Say: NO!

- Dare to say NO!
- X is not possible in x amount of time!
- X is not possible with only x amount of people!
- X is too much!
- I need to charge X or need X to make an exception!
 - BUT be aware if people step by for your requirements;
 - Will ths make the solution realistic?
 - Or cause additional anxiety?
 - Know what YOU WANT/NEED

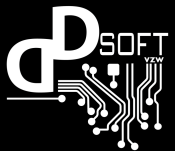
Anxious for Scarcity



- You are asking too little money.
 - You are overdelivering.
 - You are sacrificing family life.
 - You are stressed if you look your bank account.
-
- Are you scared for running low?
 - Is this realistic or only a falsehood feeling?



Part 2: Community/ OSS



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stackoverflow

They don't
believe in me!

- If I ask a 'stupid' question on Stack Overflow...
- If I don't know each datatype of the language that I use, even the lesser known ones...
- If I don't find the right terminology to Google it...
- If I make a typo in a GitHub repo...
- G*D D*mn I will mess up another's GitHub Repo...
- If I raise my hand to ask a stupid question at a session at this conference...

I am not professional!

- If I don't know everything...
- If I ask a beginner questions...
- If all my sessions I choose are beginner sessions (Level 100)...
- If I don't have a current job/ employer...

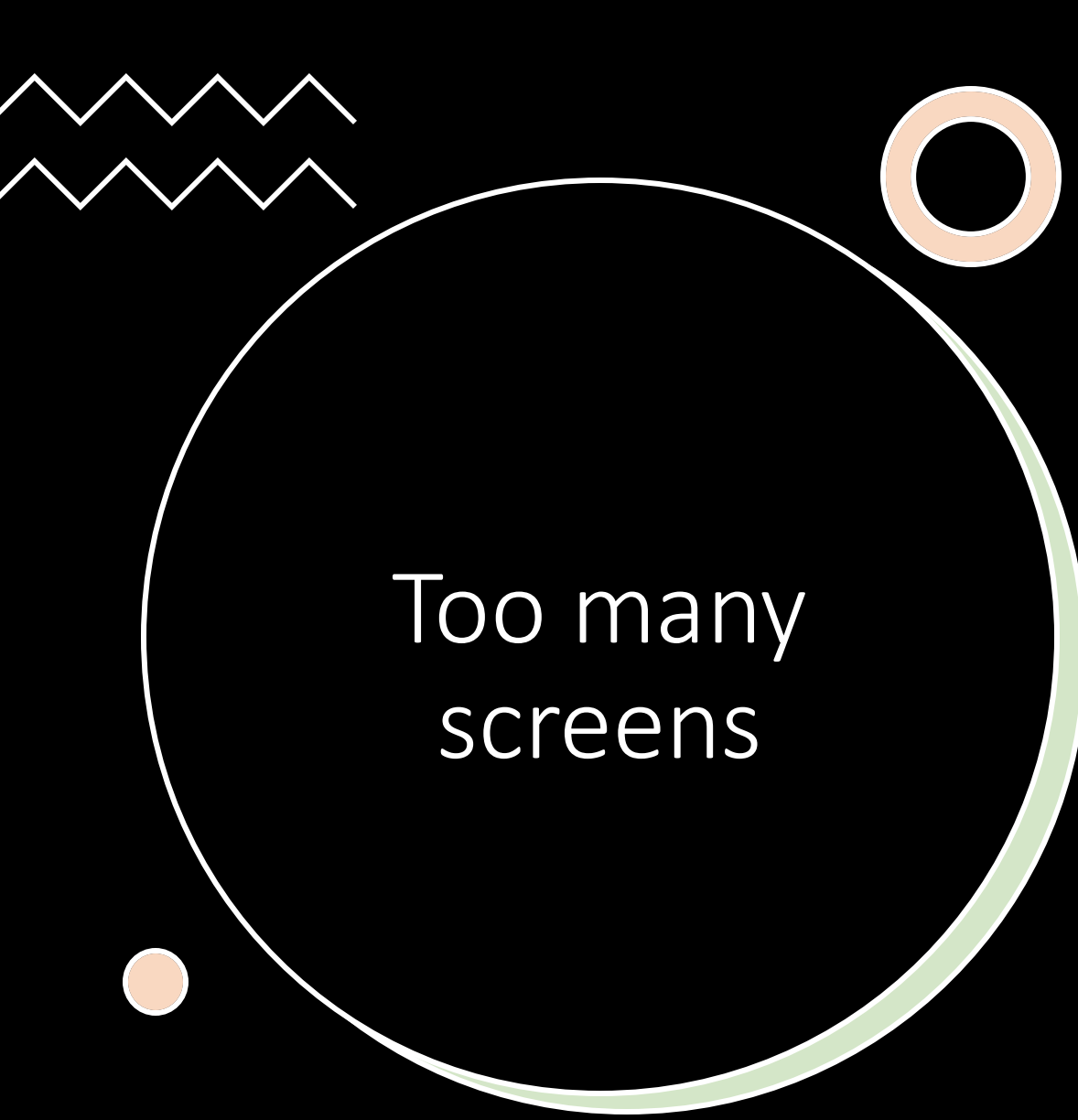
FOMO

- Being afraid:
 - To miss an event
 - To miss an announcement
 - To miss an opportunity
 - To miss the needed connection
 - To make the wrong job deal





Indirect Anxiety in Tech



Too many screens

- At your work; Or a virtual conference:
 - Multiple monitors (2+, 3+)
 - Your dev work takes 1 or 2
- What about the other?
- Power off?
- Let it on?
- Sneaky following the news?
- Doomscrolling on Social Media?

Virtual blah, blah & Newspapers

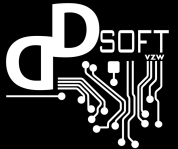




Social Media

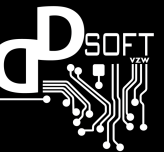


- Doomscrolling all day?
- Are you frustrated for bad reactions?
 - On your company or personal choices?
 - Do you need to react?
- Are people toxic?
- Are you sometimes toxic?
- Can you unplug?
- Can you only follow the positive stuff?



How to Cope Anxiety?

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Take a break



THE ANSWER CAN
COME OUT OF THE
BOX



THE PROBLEM CAN
LOOK LESS SEVERE
AS YOU THOUGHT



REPLACE FOCUS
AWAY FROM THE
PROBLEM



TAKE A WALK



BELIEVE IN THE
POWER OF BEING
UNPRODUCTIVE

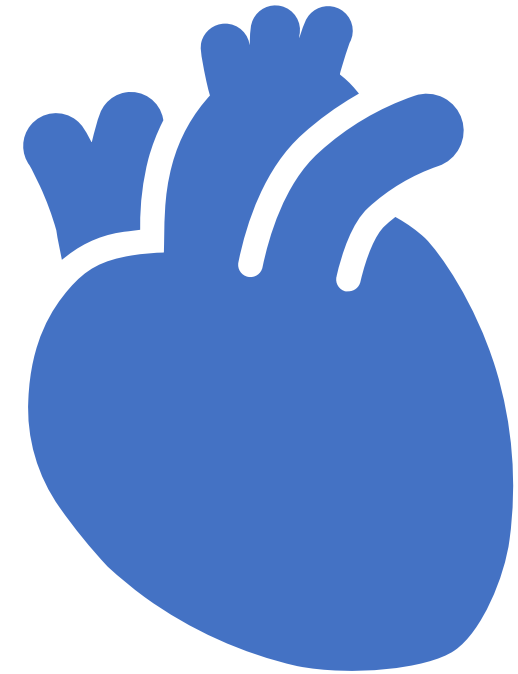


COMMUNICATION!!!

- Open & Honest
- Trust the good ones
- Be vulnerable
- Indicate your limits & borders
- You are not alone

Breathing Exercises

- Based on Heart-Brain-Coherence
- Apps
- Physiotherapist
- Some formulas:
 - 4'-4'-4'-4'
 - 4'-7'-8'-0'





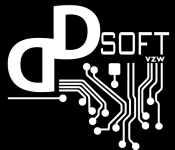
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Pressure Techniques

- Alternative technique
- Thinking about something causes anxiety
- Putting intentional pressure on body parts
- Redo until feel better
- Can cause a 'feeling high'

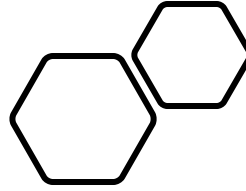




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Medical help



- My GP is needed
 - Trust in GP is key
 - The patient has rights!
 - You CAN say: I don't want...
 - Medication is no taboo
-
- "Your brain is part of your body, medication can heal the body"





COMMUNICATION!!!

- Open & Honest
- Trust the good ones
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- You are not alone



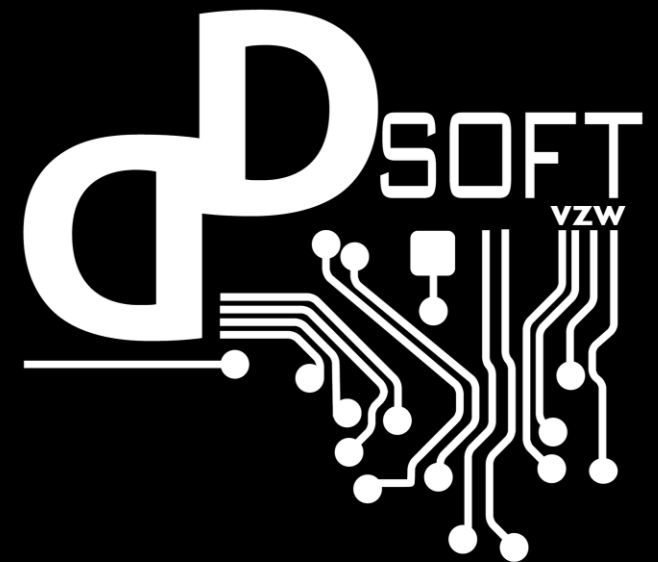
Recap

- I explained the emotion Anxiety
- I told about Anxiety in Tech Tasks
 - You can ask help!
- I told about Anxiety in Tech Roles
 - You need to follow your limit & borders!
- I told about Indirect Anxiety in Tech
 - Less is more!
- I gave tips to handle anxiety
 - COMMUNICATION = KEY!



Thanks // Q&A

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- #DreamingIsBelieving
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@DennieDeclercq